

club since I was about nine. I watched the first match of Mohammedan Sporting at Yuva Bharati Krirangan, and my father was a club official.

"We won that match 5-0, and from that day, we have been die-hard Mohammedan fans," Shahadat Siddique said, holding the match tickets in his hand, waiting to get into the stadium.

Minutes before kick-off, the clouds parted as fans with flags and tifos marched from either end to the Salt Lake Stadium. Flares in Mohun Bagan colours filled the air with suspense, and the response echoed through a giant tifo on the southern stand: 'All my sons will be like me.'

When the match began, every kick became a heartbeat, every miss a heartbreak. By the end of 90 minutes, it was the *chingri* (prawns, one of the many symbols of Mohun Bagan) that had the last laugh over the Kolkata *biryani*.

Mohun Bagan scored three goals in 36 minutes and comfortably held onto that lead until the end, giving its fans enough reason to return home with roars of 'Joy Mohun Bagan!' from matadors, open cars, and packed buses bustling through the concrete jungle.

The win almost marked the beginning of Durga Puja in the city, and it was Mohun Bagan that earned the rights for the drumroll, with the *dhak*, goals, and more.

Neeladri Bhattacharjee

Whose side are you on?

The landscape of sports journalism looks vastly different to when I started out. (Just kidding. I'm only seven years into the profession but wanted to use the phrase 'the landscape of sports journalism' in a sentence only because it sounds serious. And, I promise, I'm about to get to something important.)

Football reporting in India may not be the most glamorous job compared to cricket reporting.

Especially in Chennai, where the football culture is not as vibrant as in Kolkata or Kerala. Before the coronavirus pandemic in 2020, there were only two reporters, including



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yours truly, in the press box covering the country's top division team, Chennaiyin FC. Bleak.

Post-pandemic, there's been a proliferation of new faces in the press box. For the last home game against FC Goa, in an encouraging show, nearly the entire row (still not a lot) seemed full.

Interestingly, my new, young colleagues are often also fans of the team. They cheer every pass and tackle, groan at poor passes, and leap off their seats to fist-pump for goals. Funnily enough, I found myself sandwiched between these hardened Chennaiyin-supporting reporters and an older reporter, who was on a personal call through the first half.

The conversation sounded eerily familiar. It seemed to centre around the topic of marriage. "You're right, if you're not married before 30, it's hard to find someone after that." Wait, was it my mum on the other end? Anyways, not now, please.

Chennaiyin was ceding control, and I needed to pay closer attention to whom Owen Coyle (**above**) was berating from the sidelines.

In the post-match press conference, the bias was no longer subtle. One of the questions posed to Coyle started with: "First of all, I want to thank you for extending your stay with Chennaiyin FC, and I hope you will see more silverware in the coming years."

This is not an isolated event. In earlier press conferences, "we" and

"us" became common when addressing the Chennaiyin gaffer. I am a football fan-turned-reporter too, but I have inherently taught myself to hide my bias while on duty. Only if you observe closely would you note which team's fortunes make my backside twitch or my feet shake nervously.

Back at the press conference, after Manolo Marquez completed his media duties, several journalists went up to take pictures with him, and the Spaniard happily obliged. A senior journalist next to me quipped, "If *** had seen this, he would yell, 'Bloody, we are journalists, man, not cheerleaders!'"

It's imperative to leave one's biases and fondness for favourites at the gates before entering the press box. But it's becoming increasingly hard to miss the partisanship that comes through one way or another. TV media pundits, too, often refer to their national team or favourite clubs as "we" or "us". Media outlets in England and Spain, two of the biggest footballing nations, have journalists who proudly wear their club's badges.

While it's up to readers to decide if it bothers them, I, for one, am happy to see more new faces in the press box. It doesn't feel lonely anymore. (Unless, of course, my colleagues come across this piece and take umbrage at my observations for some reason.)

Aashin Prasad